Activity 9 — Running Dual-Track Agile — A Sprint Simulation with AI Assistance

Course	Fast-Track Innovations with Agile Design Thinking and Generative AI (GenAI)
WSQ Course Code	TGS-2024049781
Topic	Topic 03: Agile Development and AI for Rapid Solution Delivery
Duration	50 minutes · Group size: 3–5 participants
Tools	Padlet Classroom Board, Design Thinking Studio, ChatGPT or Microsoft Copilot

Learning Outcome Addressed

LO3 · LO1 · A7 · K5 — Using generative AI for faster iterations and feedback in agile sprints; lead design thinking projects.

The Real Case

Marty Cagan describes the most common failure he sees in teams that believe they are agile: 'many people essentially doing little mini-waterfalls within their Scrum framework' — the product manager writes requirements, hands them to a designer who produces annotated wireframes, who hands them to a delivery team to build and test. Each handoff looks like collaboration and is actually a queue. The dual-track alternative runs discovery and delivery simultaneously in one team: the product trio continuously validates ideas cheaply while the delivery track builds the already-validated ones. Jeff Patton's line is the justification: 'The most expensive way to test your idea is to build production quality software.' Discovery's job is to kill ideas cheaply — 'if we're doing discovery right, we substantially change and kill lots of ideas.'

Your Scenario

Your team is running Sprint 1 on the Cupcake release from Activity 8. Mid-sprint, a stakeholder arrives with an urgent new request and a competitor announcement. You must decide what happens to the sprint, the backlog and the discovery track.

What You Will Do

Learners simulate a compressed sprint — planning, a daily stand-up, a mid-sprint disruption, a review and a retrospective — running a discovery track in parallel, and use GenAI to accelerate the administrative parts of the ceremonies without surrendering the decisions.

What you will produce

A completed sprint simulation record: sprint goal, committed backlog, stand-up notes, a documented disruption decision, review outcome and an AI-assisted retrospective with three actions.

Step-by-Step Instructions

1. Assign roles in your group: Product Owner, Scrum Master, and 2-3 Developers.
2. Sprint Planning — agree a one-sentence sprint goal and pull Cupcake stories that fit. Post to Padlet.
3. Run a 3-minute stand-up: each person states progress, next step and blockers.
4. The trainer introduces the mid-sprint disruption. Decide as a team: absorb, defer, or swap. Document the decision AND the reasoning.
5. In parallel, run the discovery track — open the Test stage in the Design Thinking Studio and log what you would validate before the new request enters a sprint.
6. Sprint Review — present your Cupcake increment to another group acting as stakeholders and capture their feedback.
7. Retrospective — each person posts one Keep, one Drop, one Try. Then ask the AI to cluster the themes.
8. Compare the AI's clustering with your own reading of the room, and agree three concrete actions.

Discussion Questions

1. A stakeholder interrupts mid-sprint. What are your options, and what does each one cost in trust, focus and delivery?
2. Cagan calls handoffs 'little mini-waterfalls'. Where do handoffs disguised as collaboration happen in your organisation?
3. Discovery's job is partly to kill ideas. Why is killing an idea a success, and why do organisations rarely reward it?
4. Which ceremony did GenAI genuinely improve, and which one would it damage if you let it run unsupervised?
5. Your velocity drops because the team spent time on discovery. How do you explain that to a manager who only tracks delivery?

How You Know You Are Done

Your sprint record shows a protected sprint goal, a documented and justified disruption decision, and three retrospective actions with named owners.

Debrief — What the Room Should Conclude

The disruption is the real lesson. Teams that protect the sprint goal and route the new request into the discovery track keep both their focus and their responsiveness; teams that swap scope mid-sprint lose the sprint and teach stakeholders that interrupting works. Note the asymmetry — the request does not have to wait long, it just has to be validated before it displaces committed work. On AI in ceremonies: it is excellent at summarising stand-up notes, clustering retrospective themes and drafting the sprint report, and it is actively harmful if it runs the retrospective itself, because the value of a retrospective is the team saying uncomfortable things to each other, not a tidy summary. Watch for velocity anxiety: a team doing genuine discovery will show lower delivery velocity and higher decision quality, which is only a problem if the organisation measures the wrong one.